

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Office and Administrative Assistant English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Office assistants, administrative assistants, reception administrators, and team support staff.

All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Scheduling across calendars and time zones

Confirm whose clock a proposed meeting time refers to.

02 Taking useful calls and passing accurate messages

Request purpose, reference, and contact information without promising a callback time.

03 Preparing meetings and confirming action points

Help participants confirm a task, owner, and deadline.

04 Checking document versions and access

Repair a version error without assuming a link works for everyone.

05 Querying office supplies and delivery differences

Give order, stated quantity, received quantity, and the response needed.

06 Welcoming visitors and checking arrangements

Use the appointment reference to identify the right receiving colleague.

07 Clarifying travel options and booking status

Explain price and cancellation flexibility using the supplied terms.

08 Prioritizing work and handing over coverage

Negotiate task order using actual durations and agreed deadlines.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Scheduling across calendars and time zones

Confirm whose clock a proposed meeting time refers to.

CASE

A colleague asks for a 3:00 meeting with another office. For this fictional date, 3:00 in the colleague's office equals noon at the other office. The request does not identify whose time is intended. Both calendars are open at that equivalent time; confirm the intended time before sending invitations.

Teach this move

A calendar opening is not acceptance. State both local times for the supplied date and distinguish a hold from a confirmed meeting.

Vocabulary to check: calendar invitation, tentative hold, time zone, buffer time.

Model response

When you say three o'clock, do you mean three in your office's time zone? On this date, that would be noon for the other office. Both calendars are open then, but I haven't sent an invitation. Please confirm the intended local time so I can label the meeting accurately.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question identifies the missing time reference.

Second-round challenge

One participant calls the time lunchtime. Check their local time rather than treating the phrase as a new booking request.

Language-check answers

1. D - both local times Correct. Both local times make the intended shared moment clear.
2. C - a tentative hold Correct. The time is reserved temporarily while acceptance remains outstanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Whose three o'clock? - An assistant checks a meeting request before sending invitations.
2. Back-to-back meetings leave no travel time - An assistant flags a scheduling conflict.

3. One occurrence, not the whole series - An assistant clarifies a recurring-meeting change.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An all-day hold hides an available hour

A calendar shows an all-day tentative planning hold. The owner can release 1:00-2:00 for a supplier call but wants the rest kept. The supplier has not accepted.

Role A: Assistant: clarify the partial release and keep supplier acceptance pending.

Role B: Calendar owner: authorize only the one-hour release.

Possible opening: Can you clear that planning hold so I can speak to the supplier?

Success checks

- Name the released hour.
- Keep the rest of the hold intact.
- Distinguish available time from supplier acceptance.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes the entire day is now free.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Taking useful calls and passing accurate messages

Request purpose, reference, and contact information without promising a callback time.

CASE

Caller Lena Park needs the facilities team about delivery D18, not the finance team about an invoice. Facilities extension is 214. Lena requests a callback before 4:00, but availability is unknown. Ask for the delivery reference and preferred contact route, then relay the requested deadline without promising it.

Teach this move

A caller's requested deadline is not a colleague's commitment. Read back ambiguous names or numbers and keep the message focused.

Vocabulary to check: extension, callback, message routing, direct line.

Model response

Could I confirm that your call concerns delivery D18 for facilities, rather than an invoice query for finance? I'll route the message to extension 214. Please confirm your preferred callback details. I'll include your request for a response before four, but I haven't confirmed the team's availability.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The caller's preference remains distinct from a promise.

Second-round challenge

The caller says they already spoke to accounts. Confirm whether the current question is still about physical delivery.

Language-check answers

1. C - facilities at extension 214 Correct. Facilities is responsible for delivery D18 in this case.
2. B - request Correct. The time is requested but not confirmed.

05 • Conversations

1. Delivery, not invoice payment - An assistant routes a supplier's call.

2. A similar surname needs spelling - An assistant checks the intended recipient of a call.

3. A direct line is not a personal number - An assistant responds to an external caller.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A callback number was heard incorrectly

A caller gives a fictional number ending 0614, but the assistant repeats 0641. The caller needs a room-booking response before Friday; no callback time is agreed.

Role A: Assistant: invite and acknowledge the correction.

Role B: Caller: correct the final four digits and confirm the Friday need.

Possible opening: The last four digits are zero-six-one-four, not zero-six-four-one.

Success checks

- Read back the corrected digits.
- State the room-booking purpose.
- Label Friday as requested rather than confirmed.

Add a complication: The caller interprets repeating Friday as a guaranteed callback deadline.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Preparing meetings and confirming action points

Help participants confirm a task, owner, and deadline.

CASE

A meeting has ten minutes left and two agenda items: printer replacement and visitor signage. The chair prioritizes the printer decision. Sam can obtain two quotes by Thursday; nobody has approved a purchase. Ask the group to confirm that action and defer signage to the next meeting.

Teach this move

Distinguish discussion, action, and decision. Obtaining quotes is not the same as approving an order.

Vocabulary to check: agenda, attendee, minutes, action item.

Model response

We have ten minutes left, and the chair has prioritized the printer item. Sam, can you confirm you'll obtain two quotes by Thursday? I'll record that as the action, not as purchase approval. Can we move visitor signage to the next agenda and confirm whether anyone needs that discussed sooner?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The record states a checkable task and avoids inventing a decision.

Second-round challenge

An attendee says the minutes should list a printer purchase. Clarify the actual decision before ending.

Language-check answers

1. B - two quotes requested, purchase undecided Correct. This preserves the quote task and the unresolved purchase decision.
2. A - by Correct. 'By Thursday' means no later than Thursday and permits earlier delivery.

05 • Conversations

1. Quotes are an action, not an order - An assistant helps close a short office meeting.

2. An action needs a person, not a department name - An assistant checks a meeting note with a colleague.

3. A missing agenda attachment - An assistant helps an attendee find the meeting information.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A meeting ends without a deadline

The team agrees that Leon will compare two room-booking systems, but no date is stated. Leon can provide a comparison Friday; the chair needs it Thursday and can accept an initial summary then.

Role A: Assistant: invite a feasible deadline and distinguish summary from full comparison.

Role B: Leon: offer Thursday's summary and Friday's full comparison.

Possible opening: Before we finish, when should Leon bring back the comparison?

Success checks

- Name Leon as owner.
- Confirm two distinct deliverables and dates.
- Read back the agreed action aloud.

Add a complication: An attendee assumes Thursday means the complete comparison.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Checking document versions and access

Repair a version error without assuming a link works for everyone.

CASE

An assistant sent version 2 of a visitor guide, but version 3 was approved this morning. The older version has the wrong reception floor. The current guide is in the shared folder; one recipient lacks viewing access. Correct the message and request access from the document owner without widening permissions independently.

Teach this move

State the current revision and the consequential difference. A correct link is not useful until the intended recipient can open it.

Vocabulary to check: version, attachment, shared folder, access permission.

Model response

I sent version two, which gives the wrong reception floor. I'm sorry for the confusion. Version three was approved this morning and is the current guide in the shared folder. I'll send its link and ask the document owner to resolve your viewing access before you rely on the guide.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The recipient knows which file to use and what remains unresolved.

Second-round challenge

The recipient asks you to make the whole folder public. Request the necessary limited access from its owner instead.

Language-check answers

1. A - access permission Correct. Access denied indicates the recipient lacks the required permission.
2. D - approved version three Correct. Version three is the current approved guide in this case.

05 • Conversations

1. Correct guide, blocked link - An assistant corrects an outdated visitor-guide attachment.

2. View access is enough for the task - An assistant clarifies a colleague's file-access request.

3. An attachment name conceals an older revision - An assistant checks two similarly named files with a colleague.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A link opens the template, not the completed document

A colleague sends a blank visitor-list template instead of the completed list for Thursday. The completed version is in a restricted shared folder. The requester already has viewing permission there.

Role A: Assistant: identify the wrong file type and send the correct existing link.

Role B: Requester: need Thursday's completed list, not a new template.

Possible opening: This opens a blank form; where are Thursday's attendees?

Success checks

- Identify the completed Thursday list.
- Keep the template separate.
- Confirm the requester can view the corrected link without changing permissions.

Add a complication: The sender assumes the requester wants to edit the template.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Querying office supplies and delivery differences

Give order, stated quantity, received quantity, and the response needed.

CASE

Purchase order P44 is for twelve archive boxes. The delivery note lists twelve, but the checked shipment contains ten. No second package or backorder is documented. Ask the supplier to confirm the outstanding two and whether another shipment is planned; do not approve payment or claim theft.

Teach this move

A document saying delivered does not establish the physical count. Ask about the two missing units without inventing their cause or arrival date.

Vocabulary to check: requisition, purchase order, delivery note, backorder.

Model response

Purchase order P44 lists twelve archive boxes, and the delivery note also lists twelve. We received ten in the checked shipment, leaving a difference of two. Could you confirm whether another package is due or whether this is a short delivery, and give us the next update time?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The supplier receives an identifiable discrepancy and a focused question.

Second-round challenge

The delivery note is signed. Keep the reported physical count separate from assumptions about what the signature proves.

Language-check answers

1. D - We've reported a short delivery; a backorder hasn't been confirmed Correct. The reported shortage is known; the supplier's status for the remaining two is not.
2. C - internal request Correct. A requisition requests goods internally before required approval and ordering.

05 · Conversations

1. Twelve on the note, ten in the shipment - An assistant calls a supplier about archive boxes.
2. An internal request has not reached the supplier - An assistant checks a colleague's supply request.
3. A backorder is not a new order - An assistant discusses an undelivered part of an existing purchase.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The right quantity but the wrong size

Order S31 specifies six A4 storage trays. Six letter-size trays arrived. Ordered A4 trays: TR-A4; delivered letter-size trays: TR-LTR. The supplier can review an exchange but no collection date is confirmed.

Role A: Assistant: distinguish size mismatch from quantity shortage.

Role B: Supplier: ask for the item codes and offer a review update tomorrow morning.

Possible opening: We received six trays, but their size differs from S31.

Success checks

- Give the correct quantities and sizes.
- Keep exchange review separate from confirmed replacement.
- Avoid presenting a duplicate order as already required.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to reorder six before the supplier responds.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Welcoming visitors and checking arrangements

Use the appointment reference to identify the right receiving colleague.

CASE

Visitor Taylor arrives for a 10:00 meeting with Jordan. The office has two Jordans: Jordan Chen in facilities and Jordan Patel in sales. Reference V12 names Jordan Chen. Check the reference, contact the host, and explain the reception wait; the visitor is not cleared to enter other areas alone.

Teach this move

A shared first name is not enough to route a visitor. Ask for the relevant reference rather than private details unrelated to the visit.

Vocabulary to check: visitor log, host, visitor badge, appointment reference.

Model response

We have two colleagues named Jordan, so could I check your appointment reference? V12 lists Jordan Chen in facilities. I'll contact that host now. Please wait here in reception while we confirm the receiving arrangements; I'll update you as soon as Jordan responds.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The visitor gets a confirmed receiving person and a clear waiting location.

Second-round challenge

The visitor sees someone wearing a badge and asks to follow them upstairs. Keep the host-confirmation arrangement clear.

Language-check answers

1. C - Jordan Chen in facilities Correct. V12 identifies Jordan Chen in facilities.
2. B - visitor badge Correct. The visitor badge identifies the guest under the visit arrangements.

05 • Conversations

1. Two colleagues named Jordan - An assistant identifies a visitor's host.

2. The visitor arrived at the old address - An assistant helps a caller at a former office location.

3. A companion was not on the visitor list - An assistant checks an additional visitor with the host.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A visitor cannot stay for the delayed meeting

A 2:00 visitor can stay only until 2:30. The host is delayed until 2:20 and needs twenty minutes. The host can instead offer a video meeting tomorrow at nine.

Role A: Assistant: relay the timing conflict and the host's alternative.

Role B: Visitor: cannot stay past 2:30 but can attend tomorrow's video call.

Possible opening: If the meeting starts at twenty past, can we still finish by half past?

Success checks

- Calculate the ten-minute remaining window accurately.
- Avoid shortening the host's meeting by assumption.
- Confirm acceptance of tomorrow's alternative and requested invitation.

Add a complication: The visitor asks you to promise the host will cut the meeting in half.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying travel options and booking status

Explain price and cancellation flexibility using the supplied terms.

CASE

Two fictional rail quotes cover the same trip. A costs \$70 and is nonrefundable; B costs \$90 and permits a refund before departure with a \$10 deduction. The traveler's meeting is not confirmed. Purchasing approval is still required. Compare the supplied conditions without recommending financial or legal action.

Teach this move

Refundable does not always mean every dollar comes back in every circumstance. Preserve the deadline and deduction attached to this fictional fare.

Vocabulary to check: itinerary, booking reference, refundable fare, expense claim.

Model response

Both quotes cover the same trip. A costs seventy dollars and is nonrefundable; B costs ninety and allows a refund before departure with ten dollars deducted. Your meeting is still unconfirmed, so that flexibility may matter. Neither option is booked, and purchasing approval is still needed before we proceed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The wording preserves the actual limit rather than exaggerating flexibility.

Second-round challenge

The traveler says refundable means no conditions. Read back the specific deduction and before-departure limit.

Language-check answers

1. B - subject to a ten-dollar deduction Correct. That condition matches the supplied fare terms.
2. A - haven't made a booking Correct. Comparing quotes has not created a booking.

05 • Conversations

1. A cheaper fare with less flexibility - An assistant compares two rail quotes with a traveler.
2. A hotel date changed but the train did not - An assistant checks a colleague's itinerary.
3. A card statement is not the requested receipt - An assistant explains missing support for an expense claim.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A conference venue has two nearby stations

The invitation names Riverside East station; an old itinerary names Riverside Central. Both are real destinations within this fictional exercise, and no ticket has been bought. The traveler needs the invitation's station.

Role A: Assistant: identify the destination mismatch before requesting a quote.

Role B: Traveler: confirm Riverside East and the conference date.

Possible opening: The station names are almost the same; does it matter which one is quoted?

Success checks

- Confirm Riverside East by name.
- Compare quotes for the same actual journey.
- Keep price separate from destination correctness.

Add a complication: A colleague says the cheaper quote must be correct.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Prioritizing work and handing over coverage

Negotiate task order using actual durations and agreed deadlines.

CASE

At 10:00 an assistant has a visitor list due at 10:30 and a room pack due at 11:00. Each needs thirty minutes. A manager requests a new twenty-minute spreadsheet check by 10:20. No colleague is free. Ask the manager to choose priorities or adjust a deadline; do not promise all three.

Teach this move

Describe the total workload and its timing, then ask the person with authority to choose. Don't quietly downgrade another person's deadline.

Vocabulary to check: deadline, dependency, handover, coverage.

Model response

I have the visitor list due at ten-thirty and the room pack at eleven, each needing thirty minutes. The new check adds twenty minutes before ten-twenty, so I can't complete all three by those times. Which should take priority, and which deadline can we revise with the person waiting for it?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The manager can make an informed choice rather than rely on an impossible promise.

Second-round challenge

The manager calls the extra task urgent without changing its duration. Ask which existing commitment should change.

Language-check answers

1. A - the visitor list will miss its current deadline Correct. The check plus list need fifty minutes, beyond the ten-thirty deadline.
2. D - dependency Correct. The pack depends on receiving that input.

05 • Conversations

1. Three deadlines cannot all stay the same - An assistant negotiates competing tasks with a manager.

2. Coverage includes the phone, not every pending task - An assistant arranges lunch coverage.
3. The missing list is holding up the room pack - An assistant gives a status update to a trainer.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A handover recipient is unavailable

The usual afternoon cover is absent. A callback to supplier D55 is due at four. The supervisor can assign Jamie, who is available from three. No reassignment has been confirmed.

Role A: Assistant: ask the supervisor to confirm a named replacement.

Role B: Supervisor: can assign Jamie and request explicit acceptance.

Possible opening: Who will take the four o'clock supplier callback now that our usual cover is absent?

Success checks

- Name D55 and the callback time.
- Ask for a specific owner rather than a broad group.
- Confirm Jamie's acceptance before treating coverage as settled.

Add a complication: A note saying 'afternoon team' is treated as enough.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Secretaries and Administrative Assistants

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/office-and-administrative-support/secretaries-and-administrative-assistants.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Secretaries and Administrative Assistants, Except Legal, Medical, and Executive

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/43-6014.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.